

The term cyberspace is used more to describe the internet itself. Essentially a place online made up of interconnected servers which allow people connected to those servers to communicate with each other. Just another word for the internet, as it appears to us end-users, though system admins and companies will disagree about the internet being just cyberspace.

Coming back to Second Life, a game/life simulator that still exists today. It was in 2007 that we (Team Digit) all logged in and made our accounts, and boy was it new and fun at the time. We'd just got fed up of Facebook, or at least Facebook had stopped being new to most, and so Second Life seemed like a huge improvement. We met strangers online and chatted with them, at first with text but then they introduced voice chat, which made it feel far superior to Facebook at the time. Then all the adult smut took over, and it stopped feeling fun and started feeling seedy, and more like a red light district than a game. The fact that ping times were terrible for us in

one another in real time. It looked like a game, but there was no scripted path to follow, no quest, just do what you like, explore, go where you want. It was essentially the earlier form of the metaverse, but way before its time. Though it still exists, it's not innovating, and seems behind the times now...

VR?

Most people think of the metaverse as something that's accessible only via VR. Even our cover design follows this trend, because that's the perception that we have for how to enter the metaverse.

While Meta (Facebook Inc) and others might be pushing for this VR-style metaverse in a big way, there are other ways in which we see the metaverse starting off at least.

The simplest is the laptop, or desktop PC display. We already play games on those, and have impressive hardware on most gaming systems because of the demands of the games. Gamers are a no-brainer of a target audience for all things metaverse related. So many of us gamers have

gamers, and this means finding a way to allow access to the metaverse on cheaper hardware, most importantly, relatively cheap mobile phones. It's highly unlikely that the masses of the world will shift away from mobile phones any time soon, so it's far more likely that initial metaverse offerings will be non-VR, or at best, simplistic mobile-VR experiences. As a simple example, initially, we're more likely to be walking through the virtual shops of e-tailers such as Amazon or Flipkart than we are to be socialising and partying with friends at virtual nightclubs.

AVATARS

If there's one thing that will define the metaverse, it will be your presence in the form of an avatar. Many of us already have cartoonish avatars that we use for games, for certain services, or even for personalised gifs that we use in signatures of emails. We use animated avatars when clicking selfies, and they're also popular on social video apps across the world.

We're going to see more advanced services pop up that let you scan yourself to create avatars, and if possible, import the same avatars into multiple services. Even those of us who have not spent much time on creating avatars are going to create one in 2022, just out of FOMO (fear of missing out) if nothing else, because over the next few years that's the direction we're headed in soon.

There's a huge advantage avatars have over actual video, which is that it's less of an invasion of privacy. Thanks to the pandemic, our work (or study) life has invaded our homes. Everyone from school kids to professionals working at home have attended virtual classes or meetings using their actual webcams. While the errors that happen are PEBKAC (problem exists between keyboard and chair – i.e. the user), it can be embarrassing when you think you turned off a camera but haven't. People have ended up going to the toilet in front of their whole classrooms, showering in front of colleagues, and believe it or not, far worse as well.



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India, and frame rates crawled meant that adult content was actually a much smaller problem than a terrible user experience. And then we forgot about it.

However, nothing will take away the exhilaration we felt when logging in and seeing a first person view of a world, where people were able to design their own avatars and talk to

VR hardware as well, which means a better metaverse experience out of the box whether it's on a simple monitor, or if it's a VR display. Certainly we see a lot of the early offerings being targeted at gamers, and more specifically PC Gamers.

Of course everyone will want to scale to be able to reach billions, instead of the tens of millions of